

GNOSTICISM FOR DUMMIES

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Gnosticism is a modern umbrella term applied to a number of religious and philosophical traditions that flourished primarily during the first centuries of the Common Era. These traditions were diverse and did not constitute a single unified religion. Nevertheless, many share a recognizable set of ideas concerning the nature of God, the cosmos, humanity, and salvation.

In the present day, Gnosticism survives in two primary traditions: Christian and Thelemic. While these two may seem like an extreme divergence of the philosophy, the Bishops of both traditions claim valid apostolic succession. The Thelemic tradition – as expressed by Ecclesia Gnostica Catholica - claims valid apostolic succession:

Papus (Gérard Encausse) → Theodore Ruess → Aleister Crowley.⁷³

The central concern of Gnosticism is **gnosis**⁷⁴, from the Greek γνῶσις, meaning knowledge. In this context, however, gnosis does not mean ordinary intellectual knowledge. It refers to direct knowledge or realization of divine

⁷³ Why do Thelemites care about that? *I honestly have no idea.*

⁷⁴ Surprise! lol

reality and, through it, knowledge of one's own true nature and origin.

The fundamental Gnostic problem is therefore not simply sin, immorality, or disobedience. It is *ignorance*.

Humanity does not know what it is, where it came from, or the true nature of the world in which it finds itself.

THE MONAD AND THE PLEROMA

Many Gnostic systems begin with an ultimate divine principle beyond ordinary description or comprehension. This supreme reality may be called the **One**, the **Monad** (μονάς), the **Father**, the **Invisible Spirit**, or by other names. It is not merely one being among other beings. It is the transcendent source from which divine existence proceeds.

From this source emanate divine powers or principles commonly called **Aeons** (αιῶνες).⁷⁵ These Aeons are not necessarily separate gods in the conventional sense. They may be understood as expressions, attributes, hypostases (ὑποστάσεις), or manifestations of the divine.

The totality of this divine realm is commonly called the **Pleroma** (πλήρωμα), meaning the Fullness. The Pleroma represents divine reality in its completeness.

EMANATION

Rather than imagining creation as a craftsman producing something wholly separate from himself, emanation describes reality as proceeding outward from its source in successive degrees.

The further a level of existence stands from the original divine unity, the more differentiated and imperfect it becomes. This concept is important because the Gnostic universe is generally hierarchical. There is a distinction between the

⁷⁵ Not to be confused with the 2,000-year aeon. OK, you're confused. I get that. This is just one of those things that's going to be confusing.

highest divine reality and the lower conditions of existence experienced within the material cosmos.

The material world is therefore not normally regarded as identical with the highest God.

SOPHIA

Among the most important figures in Gnostic mythology is **Sophia (σοφία)**, whose name means *Wisdom*. Sophia participates in a disruption within the divine order that eventually results in the emergence of the lower cosmos.

She seeks to comprehend or imitate the unknowable source. From this error, imbalance, or incomplete act arises a being separated from full knowledge of the Pleroma.

That being becomes the creator or ruler of the material world.

Thus the creation of the lower cosmos is not necessarily the deliberate work of the supreme God. It results from a process of increasing separation from divine fullness.

THE DEMIURGE

The creator of the material cosmos is called the **Demiurge (δημιουργός)**, meaning craftsman or maker. In some Gnostic texts he is identified by names such as **Yaldabaoth**, **Saklas**, or **Samael**.

The Demiurge is powerful, but he is not the supreme God. This distinction is one of the most important concepts in Gnostic thought. The Demiurge frequently believes himself to be the highest or only God because he is ignorant of the divine reality above him. Statements proclaiming that there is no god beyond himself therefore become expressions of ignorance rather than declarations of ultimate truth.

The Demiurge is portrayed variously as hostile, arrogant, foolish, ignorant, or merely limited. It is therefore misleading to reduce the concept simply to that

of an *evil god*. However, it is valid to ask that *if the result of an ignorant action is evil, then is the motivation not indistinguishable from evil?*

However, formally, his defining characteristics are **limitation** and **ignorance**. He possesses power without complete knowledge.

THE ARCHONS

The Demiurge is accompanied by subordinate beings known as **Archons** (*ἄρχοντες*), or rulers. The Archons govern various aspects of the lower cosmos. They are associated with celestial spheres, fate, political or cosmic authority, bodily existence, and the forces that maintain humanity's condition of ignorance. They represent, mythologically, the structures through which the lower order perpetuates itself.

The human being is therefore born into a cosmos whose governing powers do not necessarily understand the higher reality from which humanity ultimately derives.

THE MATERIAL WORLD

Gnosticism is often summarized by saying that it teaches that matter is evil. This is an oversimplification. It is more accurate to say that the material world is not so much evil as it is **deficient, incomplete, or alienated from its divine source**.

The essential distinction is between the Pleroma, representing divine fullness, and the lower cosmos, which exists under conditions of separation, limitation, and ignorance.

The error is therefore not simply that matter exists. *The deeper error is to mistake the material order for the totality of reality.*

THE DIVINE SPARK

Human beings occupy a unique position within this cosmology. While the body belongs to the material world, Gnosticism maintains that something within humanity originates from the higher divine reality.

This element is often described metaphorically as a **divine spark**. The divine spark has become embedded within material existence and has forgotten its origin. Consequently, the human condition is one of *spiritual amnesia*.

A person ordinarily identifies with the body, personality, social identity, desires, fears, and circumstances of earthly life. From the Gnostic perspective, these things belong to the temporary condition of embodiment. They do not constitute the deepest identity of the individual.

The essential spiritual task is therefore one of **remembering**.

GNOSIS

Gnosis is the awakening through which the individual recognizes both the nature of divine reality and his or her relationship to it.

It is not merely accepting a doctrine as true.

A person may intellectually believe every proposition contained within a Gnostic cosmology without possessing gnosis.

Gnosis is experiential.

The distinction is similar to that between possessing a description of something and directly encountering it.

Through gnosis, the individual comes to recognize that the ordinary personality is not the whole of the Self, that the material cosmos is not the whole of existence, and that the divine is not wholly external to humanity. Knowledge of God and knowledge of Self consequently become intimately connected.

THE REVEALER

Within Christian forms of Gnosticism, **Christ** appears primarily as a revealer

of this hidden knowledge⁷⁶. His function is not limited to providing forgiveness for sin. He awakens humanity to the nature of God, the cosmos, and the divine element concealed within the human being. This is why many Gnostic texts portray Jesus delivering teachings privately to particular disciples after ordinary public instruction has ended.

Salvation is consequently associated with revelation and recognition.

The revealer enters the lower world in order to awaken those who have forgotten their origin.

This pattern is not limited to Christianity. The broader Gnostic structure is that knowledge descends from a higher order into the lower world so that what has become trapped within that world may remember where it came from.

THE CHRIST ALLEGORY

One of the most challenging concepts for the modern reader is the idea that the primary way that the secrets that Christ communicated to his followers survives to this day is through analysis of Christ's life in metaphorical terms.

Modern Gnostics, as well as many ancient ones, do not interpret the Gospels as a literal biography of a real person. Instead, the figure of Christ is considered a literary device through which the mysteries are transmitted.

When read in this way, the gospels can then be viewed as being an evolution and compilation of earlier texts involving killed and resurrected savior gods, such as Dionysos and Mithras.⁷⁷ This allows earlier pagan myths to also inform the modern Gnostic's understanding of the mysteries.

This view also reveals another hidden layer within the epistles of Paul which contain both an esoteric and exoteric message⁷⁸ for those who have eyes to see.

⁷⁶ See "The Legacy of the Savior God" subsequently in this section

⁷⁷ Timothy Freke and Peter Gandy, *The Jesus Mysteries: Was the "Original Jesus" a Pagan God?* (London: Thorsons, 1999)

⁷⁸ Elaine H. Pagels, *The Gnostic Paul: Gnostic Exegesis of the Pauline Letters*

Even more of the mysteries that Jesus transmitted to the disciples survives through the texts not included in the canonical gospels also. The Gospel of Thomas⁷⁹ is a particularly famous example.

In this sense, the Gnostic practitioner is not disheartened by the prospect that Jesus was not a real historical figure. On the contrary, this is the very key by which the mysteries are unlocked.

SALVATION

Gnostic salvation can therefore be understood as a movement from *ignorance to knowledge*, from *forgetfulness to remembrance*, and from *separation to reintegration*.

The individual awakens to the divine element within, recognizes the limitations of the lower order, and begins *a return toward the source*.

The exact process varies between traditions. Some describe the soul ascending through celestial spheres *after death*. Others emphasize spiritual transformation *during life*. Some develop elaborate cosmologies involving passwords, seals, initiations, or knowledge required to pass the Archons.

Beneath these differences lies a common pattern: *Something originating in the divine has become immersed in limitation, forgotten its origin, and must awaken in order to return*.

THE GNOSTIC PATTERN

For the purposes of the material that follows, the essential concepts may be reduced to a simple structure:

The Monad is the transcendent divine source.

The Pleroma is the fullness of divine reality.

The Aeons are emanations or expressions within that divine fullness.

(Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1975)

⁷⁹ James M. Robinson, ed., *The Nag Hammadi Library in English*, 3rd completely rev. ed. (San Francisco: Harper & Row, 1988)

Sophia represents Wisdom and, in many myths, participates in the rupture from which the lower cosmos emerges.

The Demiurge is the limited creator or ruler of the material cosmos, distinct from the supreme divine source.

The Archons are the powers that govern and preserve the structures of the lower order.

The divine spark is the element within humanity that originates from the higher reality.

Gnosis is direct knowledge or recognition of divine reality and one's relationship to it.

Salvation is awakening from ignorance and returning toward the divine source.

However, what truly matters for our purposes is the underlying philosophical architecture:

1. The visible world is not the whole of reality.
2. The ordinary personality is not the whole of the human being.
3. The apparent ruler of a system need not be its ultimate source.
4. Liberation begins when consciousness recognizes what it is, where it came from, and the difference between the world in which it presently finds itself and the reality from which it originates.